

It's only a game; it's more than a game. Even as the debate rages on, millions of people all over the world come home from an unforgiving day, shed their ties, pick up their sword of Blood Fire, get together with friends and head out to slay dragons. The debate, to them, is pointless. Where does the real end and the virtual begin, they ask, when life and game are two sides of the same personalit, the essence of what makes them human

pick a life, any life



Martin is a sad man today. Guild leader and close friend Peter passed away a day ago. Now there was a personality—67 years old, level 61 Druid and a lover of life who alas, also suffered from a heart condition that would eventually prove terminal. Within the land of *EverQuest*, Peter was a legend. Surefoot he was called, and Surefoot was a leader of repute: an astute diplomat who could charm a Dire Bear to sacrifice her cubs for the greater good of humans. He had the heart of a lion. Martin recalled the concern that Peter genuinely expressed when he could not log on to the game server for two weeks. “He wanted to know what happened, so I told him.”

What had occurred was this: for weeks Martin had relentlessly pursued a gruelling multi-part quest, at much cost to his real life. With the last phase complete, he headed over to the in-game character which was designed to reward him. Martin brought forth the trade window and ritualistically, with reverence, handed over the desired item—to no effect. The character did not know what to make of the very real blood, sweat and tears that manifested themselves as a bunch of pixels within its virtual inventory. Martin was furious. Here he was expecting pomp and glory and all he got was a blank stare. He petitioned the game masters (designers of the game who

answer to queries and offer solutions) but none proved helpful. The anger turned to rage, got together with the frustration now building, and poured itself out in the manner of an overgrown tantrum that wishes to be a raging fit. Martin spat at his monitor, his chair flew to the corner of his room, splintering into nothing. Still spewing pent up anger, he headed to his door and punched it repeatedly. Several blows later Martin realised, with much pain, that he had cracked his knuckles, bones now glued together with bleeding skin. “My doctor will have an interesting visitor today,” he thought aloud.

Martin expected sympathy from Peter over this tale. What he got was a series of LOLs and ROFLs a mile long. The reaction put a new perspective on the incident and the bitter-sweet irony of pain relieving anguish hit him like a bad joke. He indulged in the laughing session and felt all the more better for it.

Yes, Peter would be missed. He should, however, not let his emotions belittle this parting ceremony, he scolded himself. Surefoot deserved a grand farewell and as Master Of Ceremonies, Martin would ensure that grand this day would be. He typed his eulogy to an attentive band of elves, druids, fighters and rangers; and framed within that digital moment, smeared with tears of remembrance; both the virtual and the real Peter lived on.

Being a social animal

Occasions more joyous than a funeral are held in the world of MMORPGs (Massively Multiplayer Online Role Playing Games). Induction ceremonies, victory celebrations, levelling parties (thrown when characters level up, gain experience), even birthday bashes are a common occurrence in games such as *Ultima Online*, *EverQuest* and *Asheron's Call*. Marriages too! Women are a rarity in these realms (most of them are men) and for better or for worse, they are much sought after.

Relationships have a different flavour in the virtual world. In many ways they are more honest, more real. “It’s easy to open up to someone when he or she cannot see you,” says Mullen, a veteran of *Ultima Online*. “I have shared thoughts and emotions online which I would never dare reveal to the closest of my real friends.” It is a bonding that expresses itself as both on-screen and off-screen romance. Mady, a 41-year-old, found solace in one such online relationship—the guy even moved across states in the US and paid her a one-month visit. The virtual ground they had covered together paved the way for a smooth real-world get-together and before long, they were chatting and laughing without a care in the world. “I sold everything, moved east and married him,” chirps Mady, “I do not